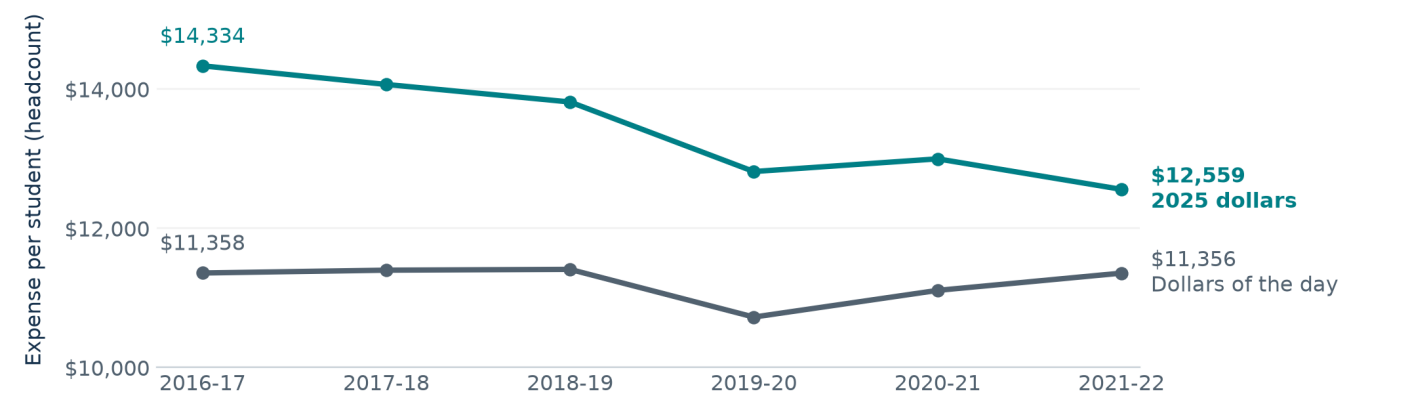


More funding now. Earlier real declines.

Funding per student is rising in the latest allocations, following an earlier decline in the purchasing power of actual school spending. For the matched public school system, revised funding increased from \$10,309 per student in 2024-25 to \$11,077 in 2025-26. That is a 7.4% increase in dollars and a 4.6% increase after inflation. The practical conclusion is to protect this recent improvement while measuring whether it restores classroom resources lost over earlier years. [2-5]

Actual school spending bought less per student

Alberta public school authorities, 2016-17 to 2021-22



Expenses exclude amortization; public, separate, francophone and charter authorities; Lloydminster excluded.
Sources: Alberta combined school financial statements and authority enrolment; Statistics Canada school-year CPI.

The historical spending record shows the pressure. School-authority expenses excluding amortization rose from \$7.402 billion in 2016-17 to \$7.719 billion in 2021-22. Student numbers grew from 651,697 to 679,736. Spending per student consequently stayed almost unchanged: \$11,358 versus \$11,356. In constant 2025 dollars, it fell from \$14,334 to \$12,559, a 12.4% reduction. These expenses include instruction, transportation, facilities and administration. This measures resources consumed across schools, rather than a change in any single grant rate. [1-2]

The later 2023-24 combined school-authority return records \$8.463 billion of expenses excluding amortization across 726,625 students: \$11,647 per student, or \$11,974 in 2025 dollars. Treat that as a separately reported level. For a recent local check, Calgary Board of Education reports adjusted funding of \$9,622 per student in 2024-25 against its inflation-preserving benchmark of \$11,048. The 12.9% shortfall illustrates continuing pressure in Calgary; it is not a province-wide estimate. [1-2,6]

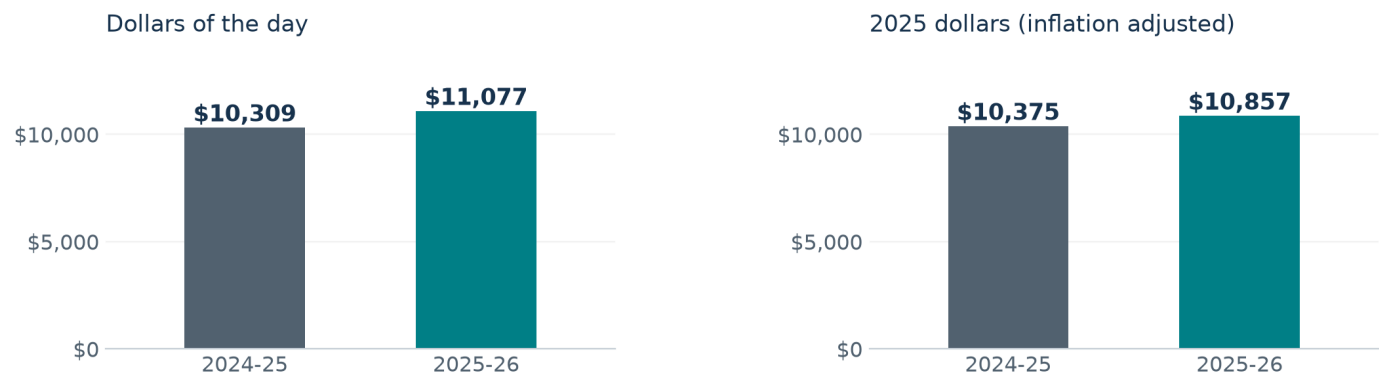
Historical trend: same reporting boundary, 2016-17 to 2021-22. The 2023-24 level is shown separately because later returns changed accounting and coverage. Student = headcount, including Early Childhood Services.

Latest funding per student: up 4.6% real

Recent provincial allocations provide a clear improvement. Matched operating funding grew from \$7.717 billion in 2024-25 to \$8.362 billion in 2025-26, while student headcount rose only 0.85%. The funding schedules explicitly say prior-year amounts include "in-year adjustments". These revised allocations therefore capture additions beyond the initial budget. In 2025 dollars, funding per student increased from \$10,375 to \$10,857. This comparison uses full September-to-August inflation, including the August 2026 release, and preliminary 2025-26 enrolment. [2-5]

Recent operating funding per student increased

Matched Alberta public school authorities; revised allocations, not audited spending



Per student = operating allocation / student headcount. Lloydminster excluded from both amounts and counts.
2025-26 enrolment is preliminary; CPI averages September-August, including August 2026.
Sources: Alberta Budget 2025 and 2026 operational funding schedules, student statistics; Statistics Canada CPI.

The 2026-27 plan adds another increase. The published public-school allocation is \$8.943 billion, or \$8.896 billion on the matched comparison boundary excluding Lloydminster. The matched amount rises 6.4% from 2025-26. To preserve purchasing power per student, the combined effect of enrolment growth and cost inflation must not exceed that increase. Allocate resources using each authority's actual growth and student needs, then check whether staffing and support services expand accordingly. Present 2026-27 as a funding plan until corresponding enrolment and spending are reported. [4]

Alberta's overall education envelope is substantially larger than school grants. Consolidated education expenses, including post-secondary education, were \$17.197 billion in 2024-25: approximately \$3,540 per Alberta resident. Budget 2026 provides \$19.388 billion, equivalent to \$3,834 per resident using April 1, 2026 population. These are respectively actual and budget amounts. This broad measure includes institutional own-source spending and amortization, excludes childcare, and must not be divided by school pupils or added to school grants. [7-9]

Matched school system: public, separate, francophone and charter authorities, excluding both Lloydminster boards from money and students. Broad fiscal figures use April 1 population at the start of each fiscal year.

Turn increases into sustained capacity

Within the 2026-27 budget, school-system operating expense is \$10.755 billion and Advanced Education operating expense is \$7.110 billion, a combined \$17.865 billion before other expense categories. The August fiscal update leaves both ministry operating envelopes unchanged. Keep the ministry's \$2.110 billion childcare component outside school comparisons. Separate construction investment from annual operating resources so new buildings do not obscure the money available to teach and support current students. [8,11]

Make per-student purchasing power the budget target. Set the operating baseline by adjusting the previous allocation for both enrolment growth and cost inflation, then add separately costed learning-support priorities. Alberta's revised formula already gives more weight to upcoming enrolment: 70% projected and 30% current-year enrolment. Reconcile those projections to observed students during the year. Track teachers, education assistants and student-support capacity alongside dollars to establish whether increases improve services. At the matched 2025-26 headcount, each additional \$100 per student requires about \$75.5 million annually. Cost proposed service improvements against this benchmark, identify ongoing versus temporary funding, and publish each authority's revised allocation beside its updated enrolment count. [5,10]

Improve the repository around these decisions. Publish separate series for actual expenses, revised grants and future allocations. Show totals, nominal dollars per student, inflation-adjusted dollars per student and spending per resident. Use school-year CPI, consistent authority rosters and explicit release dates. Replace empty comparison cards with the substantive findings above. Preserve source documents and add automatic arithmetic, scope and chart-layout checks so each refresh produces a readable report with traceable figures. Require every ratio to match the institutions and period in its numerator. Reject duplicate authorities, accidental childcare inclusion and forecasts labelled as actuals. Keep national-comparison indicators separate from local measures, and avoid extrapolating results from three universities to the whole post-secondary system.

Sources and definitions

[1] School-authority actual expenses and matched enrolment.

[2] Statistics Canada CPI.

[3] 2024-25 revised operating allocations.

[4] 2025-26 revised and 2026-27 projected allocations.

[5] Alberta student population.

[6] Calgary Board of Education financial results 2024-25.

[7] Alberta Annual Report 2024-25.

[8] Budget 2026 Fiscal Plan.

[9] Statistics Canada population.

[10] K to 12 funding framework.

[11] First Quarter Fiscal Update 2026-27.